

Jain Metaphysics - Quick Revision Notes

Philosophy Optional Paper I | Jainism | jiva-ajiva, bondage and liberation

One-line thesis: Jain metaphysics is pluralistic realism where conscious jiva becomes bound by karmic pudgala and attains moksha through samvara and nirjara.

1. Master Flow Diagram

Pluralistic Realism Many real substances exist
Reality broadly divides into Jiva and Ajiva
Jiva = conscious soul; Ajiva = non-conscious substance
Karma = subtle pudgala = material ajiva
Asrava = inflow of karmic matter
Bandha = karmic matter binds with jiva
Samvara = stoppage of fresh karmic inflow
Nirjara = shedding accumulated karmic matter
Moksha = complete freedom of jiva from karmic matter

2. Core Definitions

Term	Quick meaning	Exam use
Pluralistic realism	Reality consists of many real substances.	Opening line for Jain metaphysics.
Jiva	Living conscious soul; many individual souls exist.	Basis of bondage, liberation and ahimsa.
Ajiva	Non-conscious substances: pudgala, dharma, adharma, akasha, kala.	Explains matter, motion, rest, space and time.
Pudgala	Matter; from pud = combination and gala = disintegration.	Karma is subtle pudgala.
Dharma	Medium of motion, not moral virtue here.	Do not confuse with ethics.
Adharma	Medium of rest, not vice here.	Do not confuse with sin.
Akasha	Space.	Gives room for substances.
Kala	Time.	Makes change and sequence possible.

3. Bondage Mechanism

Stage	Meaning	Analogy
Body, speech, mind	Channels through which karmic inflow occurs.	Open doors/windows.
Passions	Anger, pride, deceit and greed make the soul receptive to karmic matter.	Glue or wetness.
Asrava	Inflow of karmic matter into the soul.	Dust entering the room.
Bandha	Actual binding of karmic matter with jiva.	Dust sticking to a wet/oily surface.
Samsara	Worldly existence: birth, death, pleasure, pain.	Covered lamp/dirty filter.

High-value distinction: Asrava = entry of karmic matter; Bandha = attachment of karmic matter to the soul.

4. Liberation Mechanism

Term	Meaning	Function
Samvara	Stoppage of fresh karmic inflow.	Prevention: close the gate so no new dust enters.
Nirjara	Shedding of accumulated karmic matter.	Removal: clean old dust already attached.
Moksha	Complete freedom of jiva from karmic pudgala.	Liberated jiva manifests infinite knowledge, perception, bliss and energy.

Formula: Samvara + Nirjara = Moksha. Minimum bondage is progress; zero karmic bondage is liberation.

5. Must-Remember Corrections

Do not write	Write instead
Moksha is ajiva.	Moksha is the liberated state of jiva. Karma is ajiva because it is subtle pudgala.
Passions attach to the soul.	Karmic matter attaches to the soul; passions make it stick.
Bounded soul.	Bound soul / soul bound by karmic matter.
Dharma = virtue; adharma = vice.	In Jain metaphysics, dharma = medium of motion and adharma = medium of rest.
Good karma alone gives moksha.	Moksha requires freedom from all karmic matter through samvara and nirjara.

6. Answer Skeleton for a 10-Marker

Question: Explain Jain metaphysics with reference to jiva, ajiva, bondage and liberation.

Part	What to write
Intro	Jainism is pluralistic realism. Reality is broadly divided into jiva and ajiva. Bondage and liberation are explained through the relation between jiva and karmic pudgala.
Jiva	Jiva is the living conscious soul. Jainism accepts many individual souls. The soul is naturally pure, but its qualities are obscured by karma.
Ajiva	Ajiva includes pudgala, dharma, adharma, akasha and kala. Karma is a subtle form of pudgala.
Bondage	Activities of body, speech and mind cause asrava. Passions like anger, pride, deceit and greed make karmic matter bind with the soul as bandha.
Liberation	Samvara stops new karmic inflow; nirjara sheds accumulated karmic matter. Moksha is complete freedom of jiva from karmic pudgala.
Conclusion	Jain liberation is not mere repentance but real metaphysical purification of the soul from karmic matter.

7. Comparison Hooks

System	Key contrast with Jainism
Buddhism	Jainism accepts permanent individual jivas; Buddhism denies a permanent self.
Samkhya	Jainism: karmic matter binds the soul. Samkhya: bondage is misidentification of purusha with prakriti.
Advaita Vedanta	Jainism accepts many real souls; Advaita accepts one ultimate Brahman.

8. Final 30-Second Revision

Jainism = pluralistic realism. Reality has conscious jiva and non-conscious ajiva. Ajiva includes pudgala, dharma, adharma, akasha and kala. Karma is subtle pudgala, so bondage is a real relation between jiva and karmic matter. Asrava is inflow; bandha is binding. Passions act as glue. Samvara stops new karma; nirjara removes old karma. Moksha is complete freedom of jiva from karmic pudgala.